

German chancellor Otto von Bismarck proposes a compulsory **insurance program to protect workers** injured in industry.



1881

Women in New Zealand are the first to win the **right to vote**; elsewhere, they do not win suffrage until well into the 20th century.



1893

US president Woodrow Wilson creates the **Federal Trade Commission** to regulate businesses and **protect consumers**.



1914

In the **Treaty of Versailles** following World War I, the victorious Allies impose **punitive measures** on **Germany**.



1919

1890



The **Sherman Antitrust Act** is passed by the US Senate, banning anti-competitive cartels and monopolies.

1899



The first Hague Convention proposes an international **set of rules of war** and founds international humanitarian law.

1918



Following the 1917 Revolution, Vladimir Lenin delivers a **new Russian constitution**, establishing a state ruled by the workers.

1935



The **Nuremberg Laws** lay down the Nazi policy of German citizenship, effectively defining Jews as “nonpersons.”

The UK also led the way in creating laws to protect the rights of workers and trade unions in the latter part of the 19th century, while in the US, regulation of large corporations was introduced in the Sherman Antitrust Act to protect customers from unscrupulous businesses. As mass production and consumerism grew, it became clear that legislation was needed to ensure businesses met certain production standards, and the “snail in the bottle” case brought against ginger-beer manufacturer David Stevenson in 1932 became a landmark in the law of negligence.

Human rights

By the 19th century, the rights of citizens were a core principle of most legal systems, but recognition of basic human rights took far longer. The UK was first to ban the slave

trade in its colonies and on its ships, but the complete abolition of slavery was slow in being achieved. Despite the good intentions of documents such as France’s Declaration of the Rights of Man, all men were not yet seen as equals, even by the law—and women were certainly not regarded as deserving of equal rights, the majority of countries denying them the vote until after World War I.

While the “Jim Crow” laws sanctioning segregation in the US were blatantly discriminatory, an even more flagrant form of racism was made law in Nazi Germany. The humiliating terms imposed on Germany in the Treaty of Versailles, and the consequent economic depression, triggered a backlash that made the Jews scapegoats, stripped of their rights as citizens.

Meanwhile, in Russia, the world’s first socialist state was founded, with its leader Vladimir Lenin promising a fairer and more equal society. This became the model for other communist states, which at one point in the 20th century accounted for about a third of the world’s population, and stood in stark opposition to the liberal capitalism of the Western world.

At an international level, the effects of industrialization were also felt in the nature of modern warfare, with unprecedented levels of casualties prompting a series of Geneva Conventions on the conduct of war. These were complemented by the Hague Conventions, agreeing on the rules of warfare, limiting the use of certain weapons, and laying the foundations for international humanitarian law. ■